

**SIERRA LEONE**

Capital city: Freetown
Area: 27,698 sq miles (71,740 sq km)
Population: 5,000,000
Official language: English
Major religions: Traditional beliefs 30%, Muslim 30%, Christian 10%, other 30%
Government: Multi-party democracy
Currency: Leone
Adult literacy rate: 24%
Life expectancy: 37 years
People per doctor: 10,000
Televisions: 13 per 1,000 people

LIBERIA

Capital city: Monrovia
Area: 43,000 sq miles (111,370 sq km)
Population: 3,400,000
Official language: English
Major religions: Christian 68%, traditional beliefs 18%, Muslim 14%
Government: Transitional government
Currency: Liberian dollar
Adult literacy rate: 56%
Life expectancy: 47 years
People per doctor: 20,000
Televisions: 29 per 1,000 people

SIERRA LEONE

IN 1787, THE BRITISH colonized this region and created a settlement for freed African slaves. This is how Sierra Leone's capital, Freetown, got its name. Today, there are still a few descendants of the freed slaves, known as Creoles, living here. The main peoples, however, are the Mende in the south and the Temne in the north. In recent years, conflicts between the various ethnic groups have led to civil war. Sierra Leone is one of the poorest countries in the world, and two-thirds of its workforce make their living from small-scale farming.



Diamonds

Diamonds found among the gravel in rivers are called alluvial diamonds.

Cut diamond

MINING
 Sierra Leone's rich mineral deposits have made mining a vital industry, with diamonds among the main products. Diamond mining methods vary from using fully mechanized diggers, to chipping gemstones out of rock by hand, or panning for them in rivers. Other mineral exports include gold, iron ore, bauxite (from which aluminum is made), and rutile (from which titanium is made).

Rice grains

**FARMING**

Sierra Leone's main cash crops are cocoa, coffee, nuts, and palm kernels (seeds from which oil is extracted). The main food crop is rice, which is grown in the river valleys. "Dry" rice is grown in the soil on the valley sides, and "wet" rice is grown in flooded fields on the valley floor. Attempts have been made to raise production – for example, clearing mangrove swamps to make way for extra rice fields.

**THE RUBBER INDUSTRY**

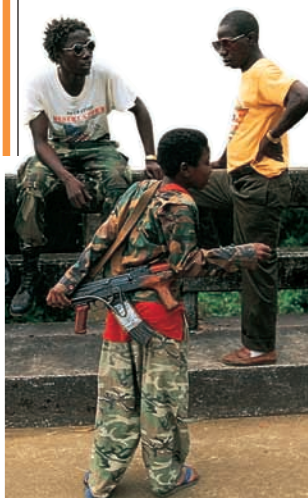
One of Liberia's strongest links with the US is its extensive, American-owned rubber plantations. Over the years, these have employed huge numbers of people and have accounted for a very large slice of the country's income from exports. The American Firestone company, which makes world-famous tires, has been at the forefront of this rubber production. Rubber is made from a sticky substance called latex, which can be tapped from rubber trees by cutting slits in the bark.

LIBERIA

LIBERIA BECAME AN INDEPENDENT country in 1847 and has never been colonized, making it the oldest independent republic in Africa. In the 19th century, the American Colonization Society helped thousands of freed African slaves return from the US and settle here. They gave Liberia its name, which means "freed land." Links between the US and Liberia still exist today. From 1990 to 2003, Liberia suffered from civil war, and the economy virtually collapsed.

CIVIL WAR

In recent years there have been clashes between Liberia's different ethnic groups, which include the Kpelle, Bassa, and Kru peoples. These problems erupted into civil war in the early 1990s, which did a great deal of damage to an already weakened economy. The war has forced about half the population to leave their homes, and many people have starved because of food shortages.



Children as young as eight have been forced to fight in the war.

Find out more

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